

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

Module 11 Assignment — Coaching, Performance & Difficult Conversations

Assignment brief: scenario, deliverables, steps and how your work is assessed.

About this assignment

Your Northstar QA team needs deliberate development, and three people illustrate the range: Sofia, a strong exploratory tester ready for more but wary after last year's failed automation push; Dan, capable but isolated and quietly burning out on the flaky suite; and the recent hire still ramping and needing structured support. You must build development approaches for all three. Where any matter touches serious performance or conduct, you must follow Northstar's HR policy and applicable local employment law rather than improvising.

What you'll demonstrate

- Coach and develop people according to their individual situation
- Run effective 1:1s and structured development conversations
- Handle performance conversations fairly and by the book
- Recognise when a matter must be escalated through HR

What to submit

- A People Development Framework covering the three team members
- A Coaching Plan and Individual Development Plan for Sofia and for Dan
- A Performance Conversation Planner for the ramping hire's development
- A 1:1 Template and Team Retrospective Guide you would adopt

Step-by-step

1. Assess each of the three individuals' needs, motivation and current situation
2. Build a Coaching Plan and Individual Development Plan for Sofia that rebuilds her confidence in change, and one for Dan that addresses isolation and burnout
3. Use the Performance Conversation Planner to structure supportive, specific development for the ramping hire
4. Standardise your 1:1 approach and a team retrospective format to sustain development over time

5. Add an explicit note on where serious performance or conduct matters must follow Northstar's HR policy and local employment law, and how you would escalate

Submission format

Submit as a PDF or DOCX bringing together the framework, the plans and the conversation structures.

How your work is assessed

If a QA lead reviewed this, they would look for:

- Development genuinely tailored to each individual rather than a single template
- Coaching that rebuilds trust with Sofia and re-engages Dan realistically
- Fair, specific, supportive performance conversations
- Clear recognition that serious matters follow HR policy and local law, with appropriate escalation
- A sustainable rhythm of 1:1s and retrospectives, not one-off interventions

Templates & resources to use

- 1:1 Template — find it in the Resource Vault.
- Coaching Plan — find it in the Resource Vault.
- Performance Conversation Planner — find it in the Resource Vault.
- Individual Development Plan — find it in the Resource Vault.
- Team Retrospective Guide — find it in the Resource Vault.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Coaching is not the same as managing under-performance, and confusing the two harms both. Develop generously in the open — but the moment a matter becomes serious conduct or capability, stop improvising and follow HR policy and local employment law to the letter.